

October 8, 2026: Sacrifice and Honor

“The meaning of life is to find your gift. The purpose of life is to give it away.”

- Pablo Picasso

At this year's Memorial Day weekend, I was relieved not to be called upon to speak at any civic celebration. Remembering and honoring, with gratitude and great respect, all those who fought and died in service to this nation is not a difficult or troubling thing at all... it should be done. I'm glad and uplifted whenever I've been publicly entrusted to do so; but I've felt conflicted as well. Those men and women who served and sacrificed deserve our grateful reflection and respect and so much more from us all. It is good to remember and honor, to offer our thanks again and again, and to hope for their eternal and peaceful repose.

But when we honor the soldiers are we also honoring the wars? Can we remind ourselves and lift up those who sacrificed without seemingly calling for more priority for military power and action, more nationalism, more conflict resolution forced through destruction, death and the exertion of superior strength? Oh, I know there are just causes and sometimes unavoidable - maybe even righteous - requirements for military action. And, I'm aware and grateful to believe I stand with and am served by not just the superior forces but also the nation that at least wants to be the more justified and righteous cause. Yet, as Rufus Miles (and later Nelson Mandela) observed: “Where you stand depends on where you sit.” I'm troubled by where we sit today, but recognize that where we have stood has bestowed on me and you immeasurable blessings and comforts. And yet, it has come at the cost of lives lost, shattered, sacrificed and wasted. Lives of those who sacrificed in my name, yes, but so too the lives of innocent non-combatants, lives of those serving and protecting (voluntarily or not) their own country, communities, culture, and more.



I would want to remember with reverence and gratitude all those who served and sacrificed in the armed forces. But I would hope to remember, too, those who gave of themselves for peace, for justice, for healing and health of others, and community. Those who served and those who serve now for the protection and for the uplifting of the lost, lonely, forgotten and vulnerable.

I'd want to evoke the memory of those who carried us to higher ground on which we might both sit and stand. I'd want to praise those who gave of their lives, in whole or in part, so that these other heroes might be enabled and honored too. Peace keepers and the peace makers are not two different sets; neither are the winners and losers, nor the survivors and the sacrificed, nor the honored and the overlooked. We are one. Let us sit together for united we stand.

Happy Thanksday.